

R. Michael Merritt

Head of AI | VP, AI Product Strategy | Enterprise AI | Generative AI | Recommendation Systems

Chicago, IL • [\(415\) 286-5286](tel:(415)286-5286) • bob.michael.prodmgmt@gmail.com • [LinkedIn](#) • [GitHub](#) • Portfolio

EXECUTIVE PROFILE

Executive AI leader with 15+ years of experience building enterprise AI platforms, leading cross-functional product organizations, and translating emerging AI technologies into commercially successful products. Former Senior Director of AI Product Management at IBM Watson and AI leader within Google Vertex AI Startup Ecosystems. Proven record delivering production-scale AI solutions spanning recommendation systems, NLP, computer vision, predictive analytics, and enterprise intelligence. Currently Founder & CEO of Sartori AI. U.S. patent holder and peer-reviewed AI researcher with accepted publication and oral presentation at ICICPE 2026.

EXECUTIVE IMPACT

- 20+ enterprise AI products delivered across IBM Watson, Google Vertex AI, healthcare, and commerce.
- Executive leadership across Product Management, AI Strategy, Enterprise Architecture, and Platform Engineering.
- Expertise in LLMs, Generative AI, Recommendation Systems, Computer Vision, NLP, Predictive Analytics, and MLOps.
- Led enterprise AI modernization improving model quality, deployment velocity, and cloud efficiency.
- U.S. patent holder and peer-reviewed AI researcher (ICICPE 2026).

SELECTED AI PORTFOLIO

Sartori AI — Enterprise Recommendation Intelligence Platform

- Multimodal recommendation platform using CLIP, LightGBM, FAISS, FastAPI, and vector search.
- Built contextual recommendation engine with Smart Filters and Outfit Intelligence.
- Improved recommendation quality (mAP 0.68→0.86) with <50 ms inference.

Outreach OS — AI Workflow Platform

- Built AI platform for investor discovery, enrichment, outreach automation, and pipeline intelligence.

Llama 3 Enterprise Inference

- Designed AWS Inferentia2 inference architecture (~132 tokens/sec; ~23 ms/token latency).

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Co-Founder & CEO | Sartori AI | University of Chicago Polsky Center 2025–Present

- Founded AI startup developing multimodal recommendation systems for retail personalization.
- Lead AI product strategy, architecture, fundraising support, and technical execution.
- Designed platform integrating CLIP, ranking systems, vector search, and behavioral intelligence.
- Independent AI research accepted for publication and oral presentation at ICICPE 2026.

Senior Director, Data & AI Product Management / *IBM Watson & watsonx* 2018–2025

- Directed enterprise AI product strategy across healthcare, marketing, commerce, and cloud.
- Delivered 20+ production AI products spanning NLP, recommendation systems, computer vision, predictive analytics, and enterprise intelligence.
- Led cross-functional product, engineering, UX, and data science organizations.
- Improved ML performance (F1 0.75→0.92) while reducing latency from 200 ms to 50 ms.
- Increased deployment cadence to 10 releases/week via MLOps modernization.
- Reduced cloud costs 22%, analytics processing time 83%, and improved customer satisfaction 32%.

Head of Product & Innovation / *MHK Healthcare Solutions* 2016–2018

- Increased product adoption 28%, reduced time-to-market 35%, and improved customer satisfaction 24%.

Director, Enterprise Product Development / *Centene Corporation* 2015–2016

- Led AI-enabled digital health platform serving 28M members; increased MAU from 2M to 5M and reduced readmissions 28%.

Senior AI & Data Architect / *Google Vertex AI Startup Ecosystems* 2011–2015

- Advised startups on AI strategy, recommendation systems, predictive analytics, commercialization, and cloud adoption.

PATENTS, PUBLICATIONS & RESEARCH

Peer-Reviewed Publication - Beyond the Click: An AI Framework for Apparel Recommendation Bridging Computer Science and Post-Purchase Consumer Psychology

Accepted for Publication and Oral Presentation – ICICPE 2026

- U.S. Patent (2025): Adaptive Reinforcement Learning for Fashion Recommendation Systems.
- U.S. Patent (2014): Ephemeral Social Network Architecture.
- Contributor to 20+ additional patent filings in recommendation systems and privacy-preserving AI.

EDUCATION

M.S. Information Technology (AI, Data Science & LLMs) — Carnegie Mellon University

MBA (Data Analytics) — University of Illinois

M.S. Financial Engineering — WorldQuant University

B.S. Computer Engineering — University of Illinois

Postgraduate: [University of Chicago Polsky](#)
[Innovate2Market](#) • [Wharton](#) • [UT Austin McCombs](#)

TECHNICAL EXPERTISE

AI: LLMs • Generative AI • Recommendation Systems •
NLP • Computer Vision • Predictive Analytics •
Reinforcement Learning • Multimodal AI • MLOps

Engineering: Python • FastAPI • FAISS • MLflow • CI/CD •
Docker • Kubernetes

Cloud: AWS • Google Cloud • Azure • SageMaker • Vertex AI

Keywords: Head of AI • VP of AI • Chief AI Officer •
Director of AI Product • Principal Product Manager •
Enterprise AI • AI Strategy